

Digital Tools | Enhance

looking for information that is diverse, exhaustive and interesting, a travel Web site is the ideal stopover.

Services, Ahoy!

In 2001, a Jain monk wanted to travel from Mumbai to New Delhi on foot. The plan was to visit all the Jain temples he would come across on the journey.

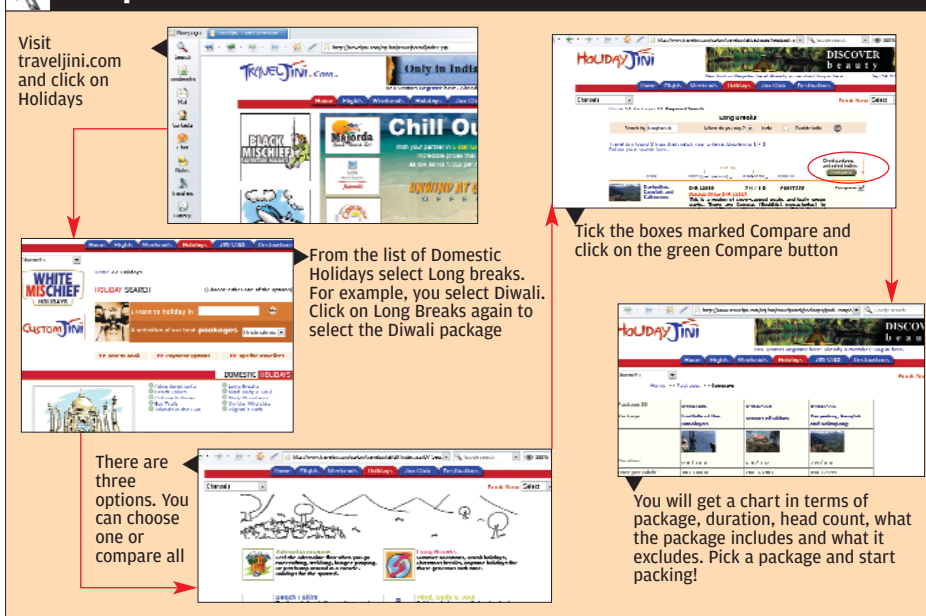
Traveljini charted out this challenging itinerary. A smart travel planner, Abhishek Madhukar made a list of the temples along the route. He calculated the distance travelled by the monk in a day and designed a well chalked out itinerary. The result—the Jain monk and the devotee became regular customers. This is the tale that Jerry Pinto, the former editor of Traveljini, loves to narrate when asked about what makes travel Web sites stand apart.

Today, travel sites have come a long way from being dubbed as mere ornamental getaways on the World Wide Web. The makers of these sites have realised the need to supplement routine information with all the services needed for such tours to get going.

Makemytrip.com offers discounted airfares from the US to India with offers such as round-trip and multi-city tours. Ask them the secret behind the discounts and Bhatia of Makemytrip.com explains that they book tickets at wholesale prices from Amadeus, which is one of the world's largest ticketing companies. These savings are passed as discounts. Others such as Indiatravellmall.com offer packages that exclude airfare or meals.

Most travel sites have numerous options for the traveller. Whether you are on the

5 Steps To Paradise



Visit traveljini.com and click on Holidays

From the list of Domestic Holidays select Long breaks. For example, you select Diwali. Click on Long Breaks again to select the Diwali package

There are three options. You can choose one or compare all

Tick the boxes marked Compare and click on the green Compare button

You will get a chart in terms of package, duration, head count, what the package includes and what it excludes. Pick a package and start packing!

lookout for a hectic adventure or a quiet spiritual voyage, rest assured, these Web sites have wonderful packages for every kind of traveller. A typical sea cruise is a popular choice amongst holiday seekers. Travel sites offer good deals on cruises such as the MV Vrinda, which takes one around the idyllic backwaters of Kerala. The tour entails provisions for car rentals and hotel stay.

Comparison packages within a category are often presented, throwing open a wide variety of choices for the average traveller. Traveljini.com, for example, lets you choose the best adventure package, while Outlooktraveller.com lets you search for the best deals that suit your pocket.

Enhance The Experience

The essential idea for any travel site is to make the trip a memorable experience. And the sites offer loads of features. Traveljini, for example, offers a Jini membership that offers discounts on all of its trips. They assign a travel specialist to you, to help you chart your holiday plans better. Outlooktraveller.com and Indiatravellmall.com have message boards and forums that let you interact with fellow travellers. Makemytrip.com has a dedicated toll-free telephone number for the US, Canada and India. It even runs live Web-chat sessions to handle queries from would-be travellers.

Everyone has a dream destination; yet, one is also perpetually on

the lookout for fair price deals for different holiday trips. Tripadvisor.com ensures that once you sign up for their Dealadvisor or Tripwatch newsletter, you are regularly updated on the best packages available.

A big advantage with these sites is that they allow payment through secure channels, such as PayPal. They also accept credit cards. In fact, ICICI even gives travel loans that can be repaid in easy monthly instalments.

Stress-free Vacations

The idea of going on a vacation is to spend the time relaxing. However, we invariably exert ourselves checking up with tour operators, arranging for the food, and ending up at the wrong places in the hunt for information. This is where travel sites come into the picture. As Bhatia says, "The advantage to a customer is in getting real-time booking for all elements of travel, and for a service provider in reaching the customer directly." He feels that travel sites will not only market India internationally, but will also bring tech-savvy Indians closer to other countries.

Robert Frost put it best: "Two roads diverged in a wood, and I took the one less travelled by, and that has made all the difference." If you are planning that vacation, go the Internet way, and make your holidays more fun and less stress.

Bon Voyage! ☒

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Travel Web Sites To Check Out

- ▶ **www.traveljini.com:** An Indian portal set up in 2000. It has tie-ups with ICICI, HSBC and Baazee. It offers a host of domestic and international packages
- ▶ **www.outlooktraveller.com:** A portal from the Outlook Group, it offers a comprehensive list of destinations and theme holidays. Worth checking are the holiday deals and travelling experiences posted by members
- ▶ **www.makemytrip.com:** The portal is preferred by NRIs for its great planning of itineraries. Ideal for those looking for good deals to visit relatives and friends abroad
- ▶ **www.tripadvisor.com:** A US-based site with details on different destinations along with best package deals and a forum to post and share experiences